

Collaborative Team Facilitation Training Design



Prepared for:
School-Based Instructional Leadership Team

Marcelo Vargas

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Dr. Guieswende Rouamba

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Executive Summary

Statement of Need & Project Background

Collaborative Team (CT) meetings vary in effectiveness due to inconsistent facilitation and limited formal training. The current state reflects informal practices, while the desired state includes structured, data-driven meetings that produce actionable outcomes. This project addresses that instructional gap through a job-embedded facilitation training.

Target Learner Analysis

The learners are secondary CT facilitators with strong instructional knowledge but limited facilitation training. They are motivated by improving efficiency and student outcomes but face time constraints and varying leadership confidence. The design emphasizes practical, immediately applicable tools.

Performance & Learning Contexts, & Alignment of them

The performance context is CT meetings where facilitators guide discussion and analyze data to inform instruction. The learning context mirrors this through a 90-minute session using authentic materials and real tasks. This alignment supports immediate transfer of skills.

Cultural Context

School culture values autonomy, professionalism, and efficient use of time. Facilitators must lead peers without formal authority, requiring structured yet respectful strategies. The training is framed as improving efficiency rather than adding work.

Overall Instructional Goal

The training enables CT facilitators to plan and lead structured, data-driven meetings that produce clear instructional decisions and actionable next steps.

Summary of the Content & Progression of the Instruction

The instruction is a 90-minute, synchronous workshop that follows a linear progression of modeling, practice, and application. Participants analyze ineffective practices, learn structured facilitation strategies, and apply them to real CT agendas. Authentic tasks support immediate transfer.

Theoretical Basis for the Design & Foundational Assumptions about Learning

The design is grounded in adult learning theory, cognitive load theory, and situated learning theory. It assumes learning is most effective when it is relevant, structured, and applied in context. The training prioritizes modeling, rehearsal, and application.

Content

Content focuses on high-impact facilitation skills such as agenda structuring, data analysis, and facilitation language. Topics are prioritized based on importance and sequenced from awareness to application. Strategies and assessments are aligned to real-world performance tasks.

Technology/Media Plan

The training uses face-to-face delivery supported by tools such as Canva, Google Slides, Google Docs, and Zoom if needed. Materials include templates, facilitation guides, and authentic CT resources in accessible formats. These tools support collaboration, usability, and immediate application while remaining cost-effective and familiar.

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I. Introduction

Statement of Need & Project Background

This proposal is for the design of a short, job-embedded professional learning experience focused on improving the effectiveness of Collaborative Teams (CTs) in a secondary school setting. The project is being submitted by the instructional designer for consideration by school-based instructional leadership and other stakeholders responsible for supporting collaborative professional learning.

Collaborative Teams are regularly scheduled and widely implemented as part of teachers' professional responsibilities. However, while CTs are intended to support instructional planning and data-driven decision-making, the effectiveness of CT meetings varies significantly across teams and departments. CT facilitators are often assigned based on role or experience and typically receive limited formal preparation in how to plan, facilitate, and sustain effective CT meetings. As a result, CT meetings frequently focus on logistical concerns or surface-level discussion rather than on deep instructional analysis.

The current situation (what is) is that CT facilitation practices are inconsistent and largely informal. The ideal situation (what should be) is one in which CT facilitators possess a shared understanding of effective meeting structures, facilitation strategies, and collaborative protocols that lead to actionable instructional outcomes. The gap between these two conditions represents an instructional need related to facilitator knowledge and skill development. The proposed training will address this gap by providing CT facilitators with targeted instruction on effective CT facilitation practices that can be immediately applied within their existing meeting contexts.

Target Learner Analysis

The target learners for this project are secondary school Collaborative Team (CT) facilitators. These individuals were identified through school leadership as teachers responsible for planning and guiding CT meetings within their departments. In most cases, facilitators were selected based on experience, subject expertise, or informal leadership roles rather than formal preparation in facilitation practices.

To determine learner characteristics, information was gathered through informal observation of CT meetings, discussion with instructional leadership, and personal experience participating in and facilitating CT structures.

TABLE 1

Characteristics	Implications for Design
Demographic & Group Data	
• Licensed secondary teachers • Represent multiple content areas (Math, English, Science, Social Studies, ESOL, electives) • Range from early-career to veteran educators • Selected as facilitators based on experience, not formal facilitation training	• Training must apply across content areas. • Examples should be cross-disciplinary. • Avoid content-specific framing; focus on facilitation behaviors.
Prior Knowledge	
• Strong content knowledge • Experience participating in CT meetings • Familiar with curriculum pacing and assessment data • Limited explicit training in facilitation protocols	• Instruction should not reteach instructional content. • Focus on meeting structure and facilitation skills. • Use authentic CT materials (agendas, data, student work).
Cognitive Characteristics	
• Comfortable analyzing data and instructional practices • Capable of abstract reasoning and professional dialogue • High cognitive load due to full teaching responsibilities	• Training must be concise and structured. • Chunk information into usable tools. • Provide templates and job aids to reduce cognitive load.

Characteristics	Implications for Design
Motivational Characteristics	
• Desire meetings to feel productive • Frustration when meetings focus on logistics • Motivated by student improvement • Sensitive to additional workload	• Training must be immediately applicable. • Frame facilitation as efficiency, not added work. • Emphasize improved outcomes and time management.
Leadership Confidence & Group Dynamics	
• Varying comfort leading peers • Some facilitators avoid conflict • Peer leadership without formal authority	• Include modeling of facilitation language. • Provide sentence stems and structured protocols. • Include rehearsal opportunities for managing group dynamics.
Physiological / Accessibility Factors	
• No anticipated physical limitations impacting participation • School-based learning environments	• Ensure accessible materials (digital + printable). • Provide clear visuals and structured layouts.

Overall, CT facilitators are experienced educators with strong instructional knowledge but limited formal preparation in structured facilitation practices. The instructional gap is skill-based, not knowledge-based. Facilitators need clear structures, protocols, and practical tools that help them guide collaborative meetings toward deeper instructional analysis and actionable outcomes. Because these are adult learners operating within tight schedules, the learning experience must be job-embedded, efficient, and immediately transferable to their next CT meeting.

Performance & Learning Contexts

The performance context for this project is the secondary school Collaborative Team meeting. This is where facilitators will use the knowledge, skills, and attitudes developed in the training. CT meetings typically take place in classrooms, conference rooms, or virtual platforms during scheduled collaboration blocks that last about 45 to 90 minutes.

Facilitators are responsible for planning the agenda, guiding discussion, analyzing student data, and ensuring the team leaves with clear instructional next steps. They are leading peers, not supervising them, which means they must rely on structure and influence rather than authority. There are also expectations from administration that meetings focus on data and instructional impact.

The physical environment includes access to student performance data, curriculum documents, and meeting space. The social environment includes varying levels of buy-in, different personalities, and limited time. The skills developed in this training, such as structured facilitation, use of protocols, focused questioning, and producing actionable outcomes, directly align with what facilitators must do in this setting.

The learning context will be a 90 minute, face to face, synchronous professional learning session conducted during a scheduled school-based professional learning block. The session will take place in a school meeting space and will be facilitated by the instructional designer in collaboration with school-based instructional leadership. If necessary due to scheduling constraints, the session may be delivered synchronously via Zoom using breakout rooms while maintaining the same structure and interactive components.

Participants will work with real CT materials such as agendas, assessment data, and curriculum documents. The learning environment mirrors the performance environment because it takes place in the same school setting and within similar time constraints. Time is limited, so the training must be focused and practical.

Alignment is intentionally built into the design to support transfer. Facilitators will revise an actual upcoming CT agenda during the session. They will practice using structured data analysis protocols with real student data. They will also rehearse responses to common facilitation challenges such as keeping discussion focused or encouraging participation.

The tools introduced in training, including agenda templates and facilitation sentence stems, will be the same tools used in live meetings. Because the learning tasks closely reflect real CT responsibilities and operate within similar time and social constraints, the training increases the likelihood that facilitators will apply the new skills directly in their performance context.

Cultural Context

The culture of secondary schools directly shapes how this training must be designed. Teachers value professionalism and autonomy, and peer leadership can be sensitive. Because facilitators are leading colleagues rather than supervising them, the tone of the training must respect that dynamic. Facilitation improvement cannot be positioned as remediation. Instead, it should be framed as a way to make meetings more focused, more productive, and more aligned to student learning.

Time is also a defining cultural factor in schools. Meetings operate within fixed schedules, and teachers already feel pressure from competing responsibilities. The design must emphasize efficiency and clarity. Strategies should demonstrate how stronger structure leads to better outcomes within the same amount of time, not by adding more time.

There are also varying levels of comfort with peer leadership. Some facilitators feel confident guiding discussion, while others hesitate to redirect colleagues or push for deeper analysis. Modeling facilitation language and providing structured protocols reduces ambiguity and increases facilitator confidence. Within this cultural context, clarity and structure support both professionalism and trust.

Overall Instructional Goal

The job-embedded professional learning experience will enable secondary school Collaborative Team facilitators to effectively plan and lead structured, data-driven CT meetings that produce clear instructional decisions and actionable next steps aligned to student learning outcomes.

II. Instructional Treatment

Summary of the Content & Progression of the Instruction

This professional learning experience is a structured, job-embedded facilitation workshop designed for secondary Collaborative Team (CT) facilitators. The session focuses on strengthening meeting structure, improving facilitation behaviors, and increasing the likelihood that CT meetings result in clear instructional decisions and actionable next steps aligned to student learning.

The training will be delivered as a 90 minute, face to face, synchronous session during a scheduled professional learning block within the school day. If necessary, it may be delivered synchronously via Zoom using breakout rooms. The facilitator will be the instructional designer in collaboration with school-based instructional leadership.

CT facilitators will be invited to participate through direct communication from school leadership (faculty email and meeting announcement). Participation is targeted specifically to identified CT facilitators.

The instruction follows a linear progression structured around modeling, guided practice, rehearsal, and application:

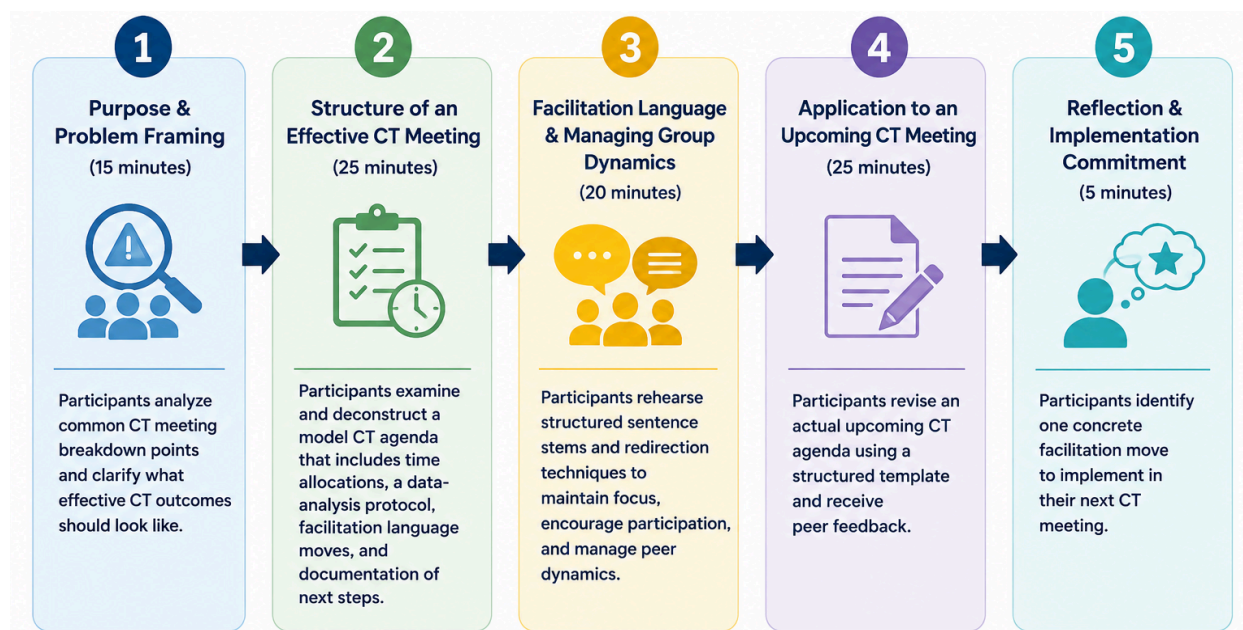


Figure 1. Professional Development Session Flow

Because the learning tasks use authentic CT materials and mirror real meeting constraints, the training environment closely resembles the performance environment. This alignment increases the likelihood of immediate transfer of skills to live CT meetings.

Theoretical Basis for Design & Foundational Assumptions about Learning

The design of this professional learning experience is grounded in adult learning theory (Knowles), cognitive load theory, and situated learning theory. Together, these frameworks inform both the structure of the session and the instructional strategies used.

Adult learning theory assumes that adult learners are self-directed, bring prior experience, and value instruction that is immediately relevant to their professional context. Because CT facilitators are experienced educators with strong instructional knowledge, the session avoids abstract theory and instead focuses on practical tools that can be implemented

immediately. Participants work directly with their own CT agendas and real student data, reinforcing relevance and autonomy.

Cognitive load theory assumes that working memory is limited and that excessive information reduces transfer. To address this, the instruction is intentionally concise and structured. Information is chunked into clear sections, and job aids such as agenda templates and facilitation sentence stems reduce extraneous cognitive load. Rather than presenting multiple competing models of facilitation, the design centers on one clear, repeatable structure.

Situated learning theory suggests that learning transfers more effectively when it closely resembles the performance context. The session mirrors the actual CT environment by using authentic materials, realistic time constraints, and peer interaction structures similar to those experienced during CT meetings. Participants rehearse facilitation language and apply tools to real upcoming meetings, increasing contextual similarity and transfer.

Underlying these theoretical choices is the assumption that facilitation is a learnable skill that improves through modeling, rehearsal, feedback, and immediate application. Therefore, the design prioritizes guided practice and behavioral rehearsal over lecture based delivery.

Content

The content for this training was identified through observation of Collaborative Team (CT) meetings, discussion with instructional leadership, and analysis of common facilitation breakdowns. These sources highlighted a consistent need for stronger structure, clearer facilitation moves, and more intentional use of data during meetings. Because the instructional gap is skill based rather than knowledge based, the content focuses on practical facilitation behaviors that can be applied immediately.

Content was prioritized based on its importance and frequency within CT meetings, with an emphasis on high impact practices that directly influence meeting effectiveness. The instruction focuses on “need to know” skills rather than “nice to know” information. These include structuring effective CT agendas, using data analysis tools, applying facilitation language to guide discussion, and ensuring meetings result in clear instructional next steps.

The content is sequenced in a linear progression to support skill development. Participants first examine ineffective versus effective CT meetings to build awareness of the problem. They then learn the components of a structured meeting, including agenda design and data-analysis protocols. This is followed by practice with facilitation language and strategies for managing group dynamics. The session concludes with application, where participants revise an actual upcoming CT agenda.

The instruction targets procedural knowledge and cognitive strategies. Participants are expected to analyze student data, apply structured facilitation tools, and evaluate instructional decisions. Instructional strategies such as modeling, guided practice with authentic materials, rehearsal of facilitation language, and application to real CT agendas are aligned to these outcomes. Formative assessment occurs through peer feedback and observation during rehearsal, while the final application task requires participants to produce a revised CT agenda that demonstrates clear structure and actionable outcomes.

Technology and Media Plan

The instructional materials and delivery system for this project are intentionally designed to support a job-embedded, face-to-face professional learning experience while maintaining flexibility for synchronous virtual delivery if needed. The primary delivery format is a 90 minute, in person session conducted during a scheduled school-based professional learning block. If

necessary, the session can be delivered via Zoom using breakout rooms to preserve collaboration and interaction.

Instructional materials will include a slide deck (Google Slides or Canva) to guide the session, along with structured facilitator tools such as a CT agenda template and facilitation sentence stems. These materials will be provided in both digital and printable formats to ensure accessibility and ease of use during and after the session. Participants will also work with authentic materials, including their own upcoming CT agendas, student performance data, and curriculum documents.

The selected technologies support a blend of instructor-led modeling, collaborative discussion, guided practice, and application. In the in-person setting, participants will engage in small-group work and whole-group discussion. In a virtual setting, Zoom breakout rooms and shared documents (Google Docs or Zoom Whiteboards) will be used to replicate these interactions. These tools enable learner-to-content, learner-to-learner, and learner-to-instructor interaction, which are essential for practicing facilitation skills.

Message design and accessibility considerations are central to the media plan. Slides will follow best practices for clarity and readability, including limited text, consistent formatting, and visual supports. Materials will use clear headings, structured layouts, and accessible fonts to reduce cognitive load. Templates and job aids are intentionally designed to be concise and easy to reference during real CT meetings, supporting both usability and transfer.

The selection of media and technology is justified by alignment to instructional goals, learner characteristics, and contextual constraints. Because participants are experienced educators with limited time, tools must be efficient, practical, and immediately applicable. The use of familiar platforms such as Google Slides, Google Docs, and Zoom minimizes the need for additional technical training and ensures ease of implementation. Additionally, these tools are

already widely available within the school environment, making them cost effective and convenient.

In terms of development, instructional materials will be created using Canva for presentation design, Google Docs for templates and collaborative work, and standard school-based technology resources. These tools allow for easy revision, sharing, and long-term maintenance of materials. Overall, the media plan prioritizes simplicity, accessibility, and direct alignment with real-world facilitation tasks to support immediate and sustained application of learning.¹

III. Implementation and Evaluation Plan

Implementation Plan

The instructional materials for this project will be developed by the instructional designer using Canva/Google Slides and Google Docs, leveraging existing school based resources such as meeting templates, student data, and curriculum documents. Because the training is short and job-embedded, development focuses on high impact tools (agenda templates, protocols, and facilitation guides) rather than extensive content creation.

The training will be implemented as a 90 minute, face to face professional learning session during a scheduled school based planning day or professional development day. Participants will be identified CT facilitators and invited through school leadership communication. If needed, the session can be delivered synchronously via Zoom to accommodate scheduling constraints.

Prior to the training, CT meetings will be observed using a structured observation tool to establish baseline facilitation practices for participating facilitators. After the training, facilitators will implement the strategies in their own CT meetings, and follow-up observations will be conducted to evaluate changes in facilitation practices and meeting effectiveness.

Minimal ongoing maintenance is required, as materials are designed to be reusable and adaptable. Updates may include refining templates or adjusting examples based on feedback. Instructional support will be provided through clear materials, modeling during the session, and optional follow up communication with participants.

Evaluation Plan

Formative evaluation will occur throughout the development and implementation process through informal feedback, review of materials, and observation of participant engagement during the training session. Usability and accessibility checks will ensure materials are clear, concise, and practical for real-world application.

Summative evaluation will be guided by the Kirkpatrick Model:

Table 2

Kirkpatrick Level	Evaluation Focus	Data Collection Method	Measurement Tool	Timing	Benchmark (Pre-Data)	Success Indicator (Post-Data)
Level 1: Reaction	Participant perception of training relevance and usefulness	Post-session survey	Google Form survey (Likert + short response)	Immediately after training	No structured feedback currently collected	85%+ of participants rate training as useful and relevant
Level 2: Learning	Understanding of facilitation strategies and meeting structure	Review of participant work during session	Revised CT agenda + facilitator observation checklist	During training	Agendas lack clear structure and actionable outcomes	Participants produce structured agendas with clear protocols and next steps

Kirkpatrick Level	Evaluation Focus	Data Collection Method	Measurement Tool	Timing	Benchmark (Pre-Data)	Success Indicator (Post-Data)
Level 3: Behavior	Transfer of facilitation skills to real CT meetings	Pre- and post-observation of CT meetings	CT Facilitation Observation Rubric (agenda use, questioning, focus, outcomes)	Before training and 2–4 weeks after	Meetings are inconsistent, focus on logistics, limited actionable outcomes	Observable increase in structured facilitation, data use, and actionable next steps
Level 4: Results	Impact on meeting effectiveness and instructional decision-making	Review of CT artifacts and meeting outputs	CT agendas, notes, and action plans	4–6 weeks after training	Limited evidence of instructional decisions or follow-through	Meetings consistently produce clear instructional decisions aligned to student learning

Baseline data collected during pre-training observations will serve as a comparison point for post-training performance. This evaluation approach ensures that the effectiveness of the training is measured not only by participant perception, but by observable changes in real world practice.

Conclusion

This instructional design plan outlines a job-embedded professional learning experience aimed at improving Collaborative Team (CT) facilitation and meeting effectiveness. The design emphasizes practical tools, structured protocols, and alignment to real meeting contexts to support immediate application.

Stakeholders are encouraged to review this plan and provide feedback regarding its alignment, feasibility, and implementation. Approval of this plan will support the development and delivery of the proposed training.